

Kevin Rouff

KevinRouff@Gmail.com / [LinkedIn](#) / French-American, full EU, UK and US work rights

PROFILE

I've spent nearly a decade bringing new technology and materials to skeptical audiences across heavy industry, mining, government and design, across 10+ countries. For six years I co-led a small team with no authority, no resources and nobody to delegate to; I defined the work, won the contracts and delivered them, moving fluidly between the lab, C-suite and factory floor. I've learned that the bottleneck on new technology is rarely the technology itself, and closing that gap is what I've spent my career doing. I'm now eager to direct that towards a mission that compounds, alongside an ambitious, talent-dense team.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Founder in Residence | *Entrepreneur First* (Talent investor & company-building programme)

Apr - Jul 2026 | London

Developed and stress-tested company theses across AI and heavy industry, from extraction metallurgy and critical minerals to AI infrastructure. Grew comfortable across the AI tooling stack and vibe coding. Left to work on the same problems from inside an operating company.

Co-Founder and Director | *ThusThat* (Applied materials R&D, design & consulting)

2019 - 2026 | Amsterdam

Stakeholder navigation:

Extended engagements, on and off site, across fragmented client organisations. Clients included industrial groups (Rio Tinto, Aurubis, Umicore, Norsk Hydro, Rusal Aghinish, BEEAH), government (Royal Commission of AlUla), research (KU Leuven) and design and consumer brands (Studio Olafur Eliasson, fashion retail and direct-to-consumer labels). For Rio Tinto, multiple projects over several years and three continents, coordinating between R&D teams and Corporate Affairs.

Commercial ownership:

Owned proposals, contracts, budgets and pricing, selling into large industrial R&D and procurement functions. Won a six-figure multi-year contract with Rio Tinto and brokered a startup partnership through to signed MOU. Inbound rarely arrived as a brief, so scoping and defining the project was part of winning it.

Technical and executive translation:

Designed and led all material R&D, directing in-house and contracted research scientists; one patent filed and 5+ custom materials developed for the built environment. For BEEAH (UAE), coordinated a multi-partner project taking industrial incineration ash from zero to a scaled architectural pilot, with a Swiss manufacturer and UK and Belgian labs. Turned the work into research reports, roadmaps and presentations for boards, technical specialists and public audiences. Basic C++ and Python literacy; built internal tooling for R&D logging and experiment tracking.

Speaking and audience:

25+ speaking engagements (Harvard, Virginia Tech, Arizona State), including delivering Rio Tinto's keynote at C2 Montreal on their behalf; semester-long Guest Professorship at HfG Karlsruhe and workshops across four countries; 20+ exhibitions across EMEA, Asia and the Americas.

Founders Associate & Head of Product | *AIVA* (A.I.-powered matching platform)

2016 - 2017 | Los Angeles

Business and product lead for an AI matching platform founded by an Argonne National Laboratory researcher, before AI was cool. Owned the product roadmap and UX, pitched investors, and sat between the technical build and the commercial strategy.

Co-Founder | *Rippl* (Consumer tech startup)

2015 - 2016 | San Francisco

Co-founded an online memorial platform. Raised a \$350k seed round; led product, strategy and investor relationships from zero.

EDUCATION

Imperial College London & Royal College of Art | M.Sc. (*Distinction*) + M.A. Innovation Design Engineering, joint, 2019

Stanford University | B.Sc. Science, Technology & Society and B.A. Slavic Languages & Literature, both *Honours*, 2015

Phi Beta Kappa (elected as a junior, 2014) | *President's Award* | *Chappell Lougee* Scholarship

RECOGNITION & LANGUAGES

Awards: Wallpaper* Design of the Year 2021 | Fast Company Innovation by Design 2019 | Dezeen Awards shortlist 2021, 2024

Press: Financial Times, Dezeen, Fast Company, Wallpaper*, AD (DE/ES/RU), IDEAT, Dwell, Frame, DesignBoom

Languages: English (native) | French (bilingual, schooled in France) | Spanish (conversational) | Russian (conversational)